with the outside world continued, particularly maritime trade through the coastal ports of southern China, including Guangzhou and Quanzhou. These remained marginal until Western imperial forces compelled the opening up of the country's economy through use of superior military force in the course of the nineteenth century.

To summarize this chapter

One, the Chinese world view has been deeply influenced by a long history of its settled and agricultural core along the fertile valleys of the Yellow and Yangzi Rivers being subjected to violent and destructive assaults by the nomadic and semi-nomadic tribes ranged across China's northern and western peripheries. The notion of a highly civilized Middle Kingdom, which had to pacify concentric circles of less civilized and 'barbaric' people along its land frontiers, became entrenched. It continues to influence China's engagement with the rest of the world.

Two, in China, order, peace and prosperity are associated with strong central authority, while a weak and fragmented polity is coincident with vulnerability to attacks and even occupation by 'barbarians'. There is, therefore, an implicit cultural acceptance of a need for centralism and authoritarian political authority for securing the country.

Three, Confucian orthodoxy is associated with the notion of a strong political centre but reinforced by a set of political and societal norms which regulate relations within society, including within the family and between the ruler and ruled. These norms, over time, become an ethical and moral construct for Chinese society. A key element of these norms is the notion of hierarchy, of every entity in society knowing its place and observing the norms appropriate to that place. Order and harmony flow from the maintenance of hierarchy. This is extended to management of China's relations with the outside world.

Four, there is a parallel political principle of Legalism, which posits a powerful state with its exercise of power uninhibited by moral or ethical scruples; and this too remains as an influence on Chinese political behaviour. The Chinese leader Mao Zedong, for example, lauded the